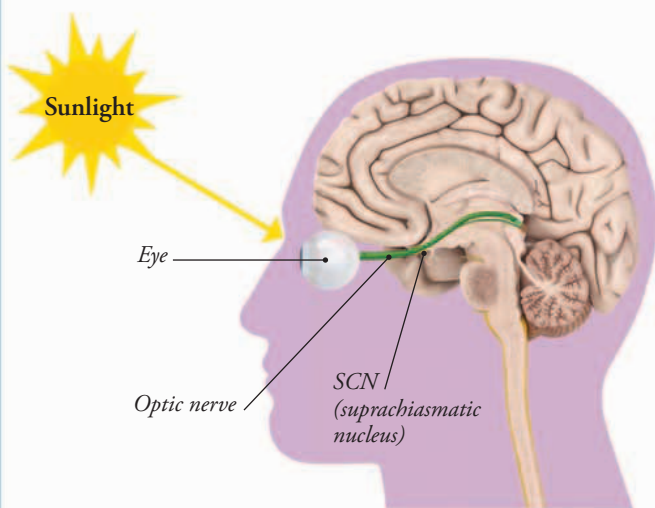


The body clock

Deep inside your brain is a kind of inner clock that controls your daily rhythms, telling you when to wake, sleep, rest, and play. Some people have a body clock that makes them most active in the mornings, but others prefer staying up late. To find out which you have, take the test on the opposite page.

AROUND THE CLOCK

Your body clock sends signals to other parts of the brain and to the body, controlling how active various functions are throughout the day. Your bowels are most active in the early morning, for instance, but your brain doesn't reach peak alertness until about three hours later. The best time to compete in sports is late afternoon, when your heart and lungs are at their most efficient.



TIMEKEEPER

About the size of a grain of rice, the body's main clock is called the SCN (suprachiasmatic nucleus). It is located in the base of the brain next to the optic nerve, which carries signals into the brain from the eyes. Special clock genes in the SCN switch on and off regularly, keeping time. They are reset every 24 hours by the rise and fall of the Sun, detected by the eyes.

